whether it was industry, banking, insurance, or investment, in which he did not leave his impress. As an economist with pronounced liberal views he was among the earliest exponents of free enterprise in India. His contribution to contemporary economic thinking was at once extensive and influential; and the reports of the several committees over which he presided always stood out for their outstanding insight and meticulous grasp of detail.

In 1936, as we have seen in Book II, Shroff was in the running to become Deputy Governor of the RBI at the young age of thirty-seven. But he missed out because he was close to Sir Osborne Smith, who as we have noted before, was in a running feud with Grigg and Taylor. What is more he was perceived as a Congress economist. He was also one of the authors of the Bombay Plan, prepared by eight leading industrialists in 1944 as a blueprint for India's post-war economy. Later, in the 1950s, as the founder Director of the Investment Corporation of India, Chairman of the Bank of India and the New India Assurance Company, and a Director of Tatas, and many other leading companies, he became a powerful spokesman for private industry in an increasingly government regulated economy. His vision of free enterprise in India was vindicated thirty years later by the liberalisation policies pursued in the 1990s.

Shroff was born on June 4, 1899, in Bombay to Darabshaw and Cooverbai Shroff, the sixth child of eleven siblings. In all there were eight brothers and three sisters. His father Darabshaw, a self taught man, worked as an officer in the cotton purchasing department of Killick Nixon. Shroff appeared for his BA (Hons) in history and economics from Elphinstone College in Bombay in 1921. He graduated in the second class but won the James Taylor prize for topping the university list in history and economics. He missed out on a first class by 4.5 percent because of a dismal 40 percent, ironically in Indian economics, a subject in which he was acknowledged as a master all through his life. After graduation Shroff applied to the London School of Economics. This was in keeping with the counsel of Sir Dinshaw Wacha who was one of the Governors of the Imperial Bank of India and who took a keen interest in his career. Wacha suggested that Shroff secure entry into the covenanted service of the Imperial Bank, something no Indian had till then been able to do. At that time the bank had a scheme under